

Word family: **too**

Base word: too

Part of speech: adverb (副詞)

Useful constructions: too + adjective/adverb, too much, too many, too + adjective + to-infinitive, too...for..., too = also, me too, you too, not too, all too, only too, much/far too

Your original sentence:

> “What made it effective was that it did not try **too hard**.”

A full family sweep shows that **too** has two major core meanings:

1. **more than is desirable, necessary, or acceptable** → 太..... / 過度
2. **also / as well** → 也

These are genuinely different meanings. Most of the other useful constructions grow from one of these two.

Meaning in your passage

Here:

> **try too hard**

means:

make an excessive effort, especially so much that the result starts to feel unnatural, forced, desperate, or overdone.

繁體中文： **過分用力 / 太刻意地嘗試，以致效果可能顯得不自然、過火或太有推銷感**

So:

> “It did not try too hard.”

does **not** mean:

「它沒有很努力。」 ❌

The intended meaning is closer to:

> **「它沒有用力過猛 / 沒有過分刻意去吸引或說服觀眾。」**

Natural translation:

> “What made it effective was that it did not try too hard.”

「這則廣告之所以有效，是因為它**沒有用力過猛 / 沒有過分刻意地想說服觀眾**。」

1. **too + adjective/adverb (程度超過合適範圍) — 太..... ; 過於.....**

This is your original core meaning.

Meaning: More than is wanted, suitable, reasonable, or acceptable.

Practice 1

> “The music is **too loud**.”

「音樂**太大聲了**。」

Practice 2

> “She was driving **too fast**.”

「她開車**開得太快了**。」

too = 某種程度超出理想、適當、安全或可接受的範圍

This normally carries a **negative or problematic implication**.

2. **try/work/push + too hard (努力程度) — 太用力 ; 過度努力 ; 用力過猛**

This is your exact contextual branch.

Practice 3 — Original

> “The advertisement did not **try too hard**.”

「這則廣告沒有**用力過猛 / 過分刻意**。」

Practice 4

> “He was **trying too hard** to sound funny.”

「他**太刻意想搞笑**，反而顯得不自然。」

Practice 5

> “Don’t **push yourself too hard**.”

「不要**把自己逼得太厲害 / 過度勉強自己**。」

too hard = 努力、施力或要求自己的程度超過合適水平

In advertising:

> **trying too hard**

often suggests:

- * too flashy
- * too emotional
- * too desperate
- * too obviously persuasive

So your passage uses it very naturally.

3. **too much + uncountable noun (不可數名詞) — 太多.....**

Practice 6

> “There is **too much noise** on the train.”

「火車上有**太多噪音**。」

Practice 7

> “I spent **too much money** on headphones.”

「我在耳機上花了**太多錢**。」

too much + uncountable noun = 某種不可數的數量超過需要 / 理想程度

Examples:

- * too much time
- * too much noise
- * too much pressure

* too much information

4. **too many + plural countable noun (可數複數) — 太多.....**

Practice 8

> “There were **too many people** on the train.”

「火車上有**太多人**。」

Practice 9

> “The design has **too many buttons**.”

「這個設計有**太多按鈕**。」

too many + plural noun = 可數的人 / 事物數量多到超過適當程度

Compare:

> **too much noise**

> **too many people**

5. **verb + too much (行為過量) —太多 / 過度.....**

Too much can also follow a verb.

Practice 10

> “I **work too much**.”

「我**工作太多 / 工作過度**。」

Practice 11

> “He **worries too much**.”

「他**擔心得太多 / 過度憂慮**。」

verb + too much = 某個行為發生得過於頻繁、過量或程度太高

6. **too + adjective/adverb + to + verb (程度太高以致不能.....) — 太.....而不能.....**

A crucial grammar pattern.

Practice 12

> “The café was **too noisy to work in**.”

「咖啡店**太嘈雜，根本無法在裡面工作**。」

Practice 13

> “The headphones were **too expensive to buy** at the time.”

「當時這副耳機**太貴，我買不起 / 不適合購買**。」

too + adjective + to do = 某種程度高到令後面的行動無法或不適合進行

Think:

> **too X to Y**

= **X 到不能 Y 的程度**

7. **too + adjective + for + person/thing — 對.....來說太.....**

Practice 14

> “The headphones are **too large for me**.”

「這副耳機**對我來說太大了**。」

Practice 15

> “The volume is **too high for this room**.”

「這個音量**對這個房間來說太大**。」

too + adjective + for + person/thing = 對某個人 / 用途 / 環境而言，程度超過合適範圍

8. **too + adjective + for + person + to + verb — 對某人來說太.....而無法.....**

Practice 16

> “The instructions were **too complicated for me to follow**.”

「那些指示**對我來說太複雜**，我跟不上 / 無法理解**。**」

Practice 17

> “The room was **too noisy for her to concentrate**.”

「房間**太嘈雜**，令她無法集中精神**。**」

too...for someone to... = 某種程度超過某人能完成後面行動的範圍

9. **too = also / as well (附加另一人 / 事物) — 也 ; 同樣**

This is the second major meaning.

Practice 18

> “I use noise-cancelling headphones **too**.”

「我**也**使用降噪耳機。」

Practice 19

> “She liked the advertisement, and I did **too**.”

「她喜歡那則廣告，我**也**喜歡**。**」

too = 表示前面所述的情況同樣適用於另一個人 / 事物

This has nothing to do with excess.

10. **me too / you too (回應) — 我也是 / 你也是**

Extremely common conversationally.

Practice 20

> “I’m tired.”

> “**Me too.**”

「我累了。」

「**我也是。**」

Practice 21

> “Have a good weekend.”

> “**You too.**”

「週末愉快。」

「**你也是。**」

me too = 我也是

you too = 你也是 / 也祝你如此

11. **not too + adjective/adverb — 不太……；不算太……**

This often softens a negative description.

Practice 22

> “The headphones are **not too heavy**.”

「這副耳機**不算太重 / 不太重**。」

Practice 23

> “The café is **not too far** from here.”

「咖啡店離這裡**不算太遠**。」

not too = 程度沒有高到成為明顯問題；不太 / 不算太

Sometimes this can be quite positive:

> “That’s not too bad.”

= **那還不錯。**

12. **not too bad = 還不錯；不算差**

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 24

> “How was the film?”

> “**Not too bad.**”

「電影怎樣？」

「**還不錯**。」

Practice 25

> “The sound quality is **not too bad** for the price.”

「以這個價錢來說，音質**還算不錯**。」

not too bad = 雖然未必非常好，但整體令人滿意；還不錯

It often sounds more positive than the literal words suggest.

13. **much/far/way too + adjective/adverb — 太過.....；遠遠過於.....**

These words intensify **too**.

Practice 26

> “The headphones are **far too expensive**.”

「這副耳機**實在太貴了 / 遠遠超出合理價格**。」

Practice 27

> “The music was **way too loud**.”

「音樂**實在太大聲了**。」

much/far/way too = 程度遠遠超過可接受或合適範圍

Register:

* **far too** = neutral

* **much too** = common

* **way too** = informal

14. **all too + adjective/adverb — 太過.....；令人遺憾地非常.....**

A useful slightly formal expression.

Practice 28

> “The problem is **all too common**.”

「這個問題**實在太常見了 / 不幸地非常普遍**。」

Practice 29

> “It is **all too easy** to become distracted.”

「人**實在太容易**分心了。」

all too = 強調某個通常不理想的情況非常真實 / 非常常見

Often carries regret or criticism.

15. **only too + adjective / only too happy/willing — 非常；十分樂意**

This is interesting because it does **not** carry the usual negative “excessive” meaning.

Practice 30

> “I’d be **only too happy** to help.”

「我**非常樂意**幫忙。」

Practice 31

> “She was **only too willing** to explain.”

「她**十分樂意**解釋。」

only too + positive adjective = 非常 / 極其，尤其常表示很樂意

This is somewhat formal.

16. **too good to be true — 好得令人難以置信；好得不真實**

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 32

> “The offer sounds **too good to be true**.”

「這個優惠聽起來**好得令人難以置信 / 好得不像真的**。」

Practice 33

> “At first, the deal seemed **too good to be true**.”

「起初，這個交易看起來**好得不太真實**。」

too good to be true = 好到超出合理預期，因此令人懷疑是否真的可信

This is a special case where **too + positive adjective** still suggests a problem: the goodness itself raises suspicion.

17. **too late = 過遲；為時已晚**

We already curated **late**, but this combination is common enough to flag.

Practice 34

> “It’s **too late** to change the booking.”

「現在要更改預訂已經**太遲 / 為時已晚**。」

Practice 35

> “By the time I noticed the mistake, it was **too late**.”

「等我發現錯誤時，已經**太遲了**。」

too late = 時間已超過仍可採取某行動或改變結果的界線

18. **too soon = 過早；太快**

Practice 36

> “It is **too soon** to judge the results.”

「現在判斷結果還**太早**。」

Practice 37

> “The battery failed **too soon**.”

「電池**太早就**失效了。」

too soon = 某件事情發生的時間比合適、合理或預期的時間早

19. **too little / too few** — 太少；不足

Practice 38

> “We have **too little time**.”

「我們的時間**太少 / 不足**。」

Practice 39

> “There are **too few seats**.”

「座位**太少 / 不夠**。」

too little = 不可數數量不足到造成問題

too few = 可數數量不足到造成問題

Compare with the **so** family:

* **so little** = 這麼少

* **too little** = 少得不夠 / 太少

20. **too much** = excessive / overwhelming thing (代名詞式) — 太多了；令人受不了

Practice 40

> “The noise was **too much** for me.”

「那些噪音對我來說**實在太多 / 太難承受了**。」

Practice 41

> “Working twelve hours a day became **too much**.”

「每天工作十二小時開始變得**令人吃不消**。」

too much = 某種負擔、數量或程度已超過一個人能合理承受的範圍

Important distinction: **too vs very**

This is crucial.

very

= high degree, but not necessarily a problem

> “The headphones are **very expensive**.”

「這副耳機很貴。」

Maybe I can still afford them.

too

= degree exceeds what is suitable/acceptable

> “The headphones are **too expensive**.”

「這副耳機**太貴了**。」

This normally implies:

> therefore I cannot / do not want to buy them.

So:

very = 很 / 非常

too = 太....., 超出合適範圍

Important distinction: **too vs so**

You just curated ****so****.

**so expensive**

= 這麼貴 / 非常貴

It emphasizes degree.

**too expensive**

= 太貴

It means the price has ****crossed an acceptable threshold****.

Compare:

> “The headphones are so expensive!”

「耳機真的好貴！」

> “The headphones are too expensive for me.”

「這副耳機對我來說太貴，我負擔不起 / 不適合買。」

Important distinction: **too vs also vs as well**

For 「也」:

**too**

usually comes toward the end:

> “I like it too.”

**also**

usually appears before the main verb / after ****be****:

> “I also like it.”

> “It is also useful.”

**as well**

usually comes toward the end:

> “I like it as well.”

All can mean **「也」**, but word position differs.

Important distinction: **too much vs very much**

too much

= excessively

> “I work too much.”

「我工作過度。」

very much

= to a great degree, not inherently excessive

> “I like it very much.”

「我非常喜歡它。」

Not:

> “I like it too much”

unless you mean:

I like it more than is sensible/good for me.

Important distinction: **too many vs so many**

too many

= more than acceptable/needed

> “There are too many buttons.”

「按鈕太多，造成問題。」

so many

= a surprisingly/highly large number

> “There are so many buttons!”

「竟然有這麼多按鈕！」

So many does not automatically mean the number is unacceptable.

Important distinction: **too little vs a little**

a little time

= some time exists

「有一點時間」

too little time

= amount is insufficient

「時間太少 / 不夠」

Again, **too** introduces the idea of crossing an unacceptable limit.

Important distinction: **not too vs not very**

They can overlap:

> “It’s not too expensive.”

「不算太貴。」

> “It’s not very expensive.”

「不是很貴。」

But **not too expensive** often implies:

> **the price remains acceptable**

whereas ****not very expensive**** simply describes the degree.

Word-position note: ****too = also****

Usually:

> “I like it ****too****.”

not normally:

> “I ****too**** like it.”

But ****I too...**** is possible in formal/literary English:

> “I too was surprised.”

「我也感到驚訝。」

For learners, sentence-final ****too**** is the safest default for the “also” meaning.

Family-extension sweep

****Too**** has essentially ****no useful derivational family****. Its richness comes from two core meanings and many grammatical constructions:

* ****too + adjective/adverb**** = 太..... / 過於.....

* ****too hard**** = 太用力 / 用力過猛

* ****too much + uncountable**** = 太多

* ****too many + countable plural**** = 太多

* ****verb + too much**** = 做某事過度

* ****too...to...**** = 太.....而不能.....

* ****too...for...**** = 對.....來說太.....

* ****too = also**** = 也

* ****me too / you too**** = 我也是 / 你也是

* ****not too**** = 不太 / 不算太

* ****not too bad**** = 還不錯

* ****far/much/way too**** = 實在太 / 遠遠過於

* ****all too**** = 太過..... ; 令人遺憾地非常.....

* ****only too**** = 非常 / 十分樂意

* ****too good to be true**** = 好得令人難以置信

* ****too late / too soon**** = 太遲 / 太早

* ****too little / too few**** = 太少 / 不足

* **too much — standalone** = 多得令人吃不消 / 超出承受範圍

I would not manufacture a “word family” beyond this, because **too** is fundamentally a grammar-rich adverb rather than a derivationally rich lexical family.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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too + adjective/adverb	某種程度超過理想、適當、安全或可接受範圍
too hard	努力、施力或要求自己的程度過高；用力過猛
too much + uncountable	不可數事物的數量多到超過需要或可接受程度
too many + plural noun	可數的人 / 事物數量多到超過需要或可接受程度
verb + too much	某個行為發生得過於頻繁、過量或程度太高
too...to...	某種程度高到令另一行動無法 / 不適合進行
too...for...	對特定的人、用途或情況而言，程度過高
too = also	表示前面所述的情況同樣適用於另一人 / 事物；也
me too / you too	表示「我也是 / 你也是」
not too	程度沒有高到構成明顯問題；不太 / 不算太
not too bad	雖然未必很好，但整體仍令人滿意；還不錯
far/much/way too	程度遠遠超過適當或可接受範圍
all too	強調某個通常不理想的情況非常真實 / 常見
only too	非常、十分；尤其常見於「非常樂意」
too good to be true	好到超出合理預期，令人懷疑是否真實
too little/few	數量少到不足以滿足需要
too much — standalone	負擔或程度已超過某人合理能承受的範圍

For your original sentence

> “What made it effective was that it did not try **too hard**.”

The exact meaning is:

****too = 努力程度超過恰當範圍，以致可能顯得太刻意、過火或不自然****

Therefore:

> ****did not try too hard****

= ****「沒有用力過猛 / 沒有過分刻意地想吸引或說服觀眾」****

That nuance is important: the sentence is actually ****praising the advertisement’s restraint****. It was effective precisely because it did ****not**** look as though it was desperately trying to be persuasive.